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SURVEY OF HEALTH, AGEING AND RETIREMENT IN EUROPE

QPIs in Large-Scale Surveys: Lessons Learned

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Qualitative Pretest Interviews (QPIs)

Key points

- Focus on **contextualisation**
- Involvement of respondents as **co-experts**
- Negotiation of understanding between researchers and respondents (**intersubjective understanding**)
- **Direct** development of suggestions for improvement
- Grounded in **qualitative-interpretative** methodology

For more info see:

Buschle, C., Reiter, H.& Bethmann, A. The qualitative pretest interview for questionnaire development: outline of programme and practice. *Qual Quant* **56**, 823-842 (2022)

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SHARE in a nutshell

Survey of Health, Ageing and Retirement in Europe

- **Biennial** representative cross-national household **panel survey** of **50+ population** in **27 European countries & Israel**
- **Launched** in **2004**, Wave 10 fieldwork started in 2024
- Around 616.000 **face-to-face interviews (CAPI mode)** with over 160.000 respondents
- Two additional SHARE Corona Surveys (2020 and 2021) by phone
- **Ex-ante harmonisation** – centralised procurement, questionnaire development, sampling, data collection instrument, and database management
- **Broad range of topics** (e.g., health, economic and living conditions, social relationships) and measures

- **Free data access for researchers: http://www.share-eric.eu**

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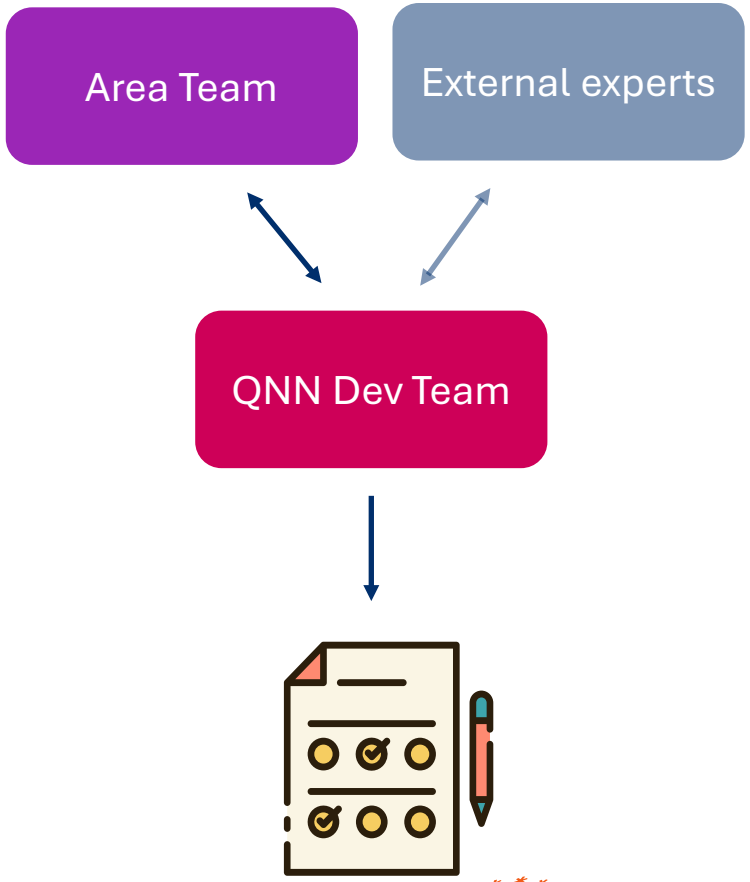
QPIs in SHARE

Challenges

- **Increased complexity in a large-scale survey**
  - ➡ Adherence to the SHARE schedule
  - ➡ Collaborative questionnaire development
- **Researchers ≠ Interviewers**
  - ➡ Recruitment & training of interviewers
  - ➡ In-house
- **Multilingual questionnaire**
  - ➡ Pilot study in SHARE-DE



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Questionnaire

IT-Module

- Internet use, access to internet-enabled devices, support with internet activities
- 16 questions
- Most newly developed, partly adopted from original questionnaire
- German translation of generic questionnaire

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Procedure

QPIs for the (new) IT module

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Training

Varying levels of prior experience
In some cases little or no experience with qualitative interviewing

Overview of QPIs
Theoretical and methodological background

Conducting interviews in QPIs
Communication techniques, guidelines, etc.

Mock interviews
Example interview in the plenary, interview exercises in groups of two

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Overview Interviews

No.	Interviewer	Duration (in mins)	Mode	Prior relationship between I and IP
001	001	42	Face-to-face	Yes
002	002	45	Face-to-face	Yes
003	003	55	Face-to-face	Yes
004	003	40	Face-to-face	Yes
005	004	65	Face-to-face	No
006	005	64	Face-to-face	No
007	006	18	Face-to-face	No
008	006	16	Face-to-face	No
009	006	29	Face-to-face	Yes
010	006	32	Face-to-face	Yes
011	004	120	Face-to-face	No
012	007	45	Video interview	No
013	007	25	Video interview	No
014	007	43	Face-to-face	Yes
015	001	37	Face-to-face	Yes
016	008	67	Video interview	No
017	008	53	Video interview	No

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011	004	120	Face-to-face	No
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Analysis workshop

in the QPI team

- Based on protocols, transcripts, original audio recordings
- Iterative process: listening to the recordings/reading the transcripts <-> discussion
- Representation of the interview partners through their own statements
- Flexible adaptation possible → Limitation to "problematic" items

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Lessons learned

Worked well

1. Valuable input for the improvement/further development of the IT-questionnaire
2. Sensitisation of SHARE's internal interviewers
3. Further development of the QPIs

Need for improvement

1. Varying quality of the interviews
2. Language restrictions
3. Insufficient involvement of the area coordinators (questionnaire developers & gatekeepers)

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Conclusion

High expenditure of resources

Preparation, conducting the interviews, but also analysing, adapting the items etc. takes a lot of time

It's worth it!

In return, you get direct feedback from potential respondents → very valuable

Involvement of the question developers is essential

If possible, in the entire process - from conducting the interviews to analysing them

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Thanks!

Have you got any questions?

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